Introduction to International Politics 1601

Structural Realism (Neorealism)

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Introducing Structural Realism (Neorealism)

Recall: Realism -

- The international system in *anarchic* (possibility of conflict)
- States are the *primary actors* in the system
- States are concerned with **relative power** (zero-sum)
- Power is understood in terms of **material factors** (i.e., the capacity to conduct war)

States as *unit of analysis* are -

- rational, unitary actors
- same; the "black box"

Anarchy -

- Lack of central authority means passive permissions of action
- States are in a constant competition for their *survival*

Hobbes: a system lacking a central authority is in a "constant state of warre", wherein conflict may always arise (8)

Anarchy -

- Lack of central authority means passive permissions of action
- States are in a constant competition for their *survival*
- establishes a **self-help system** where **states are uncertain of others intentions**

"it induces insecurity and a continuous competition for power, which makes the international system inherently conflictual. . . Anarchy does not automatically lead to war, but it creates a permissive environment for war by creating a system of insecurity, conflicts of interest, and international rivalries" (Levy and Thompson 2010, 29)

Classical Realism $\rightarrow$ *StructuralRealism*

Structural Realism (Neorealism)

Structural Realism (or Neorealism) -

- maintains the existing assumptions of Classical Realism (fund. principles)
- introduces additional considerations about states' motivations based on the **structure of the international system**

States seek power - but *not* as an end in itself.

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...for survival

Why is power (our focus) important?

- **Power implies security**.
- States seek security, not power alone (differing from Classical Realism)

Balance of Power Theory

Balance of Power theory -

- the set of theories to explain state's behaviors in response to the power structure of the international system.
- explains **system-level outcomes**

Polarity -

- the distribution of power among states in the international system:
- *unipolarity* (singular/ hegemon), *bipolarity* (two), and *multipolarity* (many) distributions

Unipolarity -

- one state having greater power in the international system
- Example - United States during the post-Cold War period

A **hegemon** -

- a state having significantly greater influence over the international system.
- **Hegemony** is a period of leadership by one country

Bipoloarity -

- two states having a greater power in respective regions within the international system
- Example - United States and the Soviet Union during the Cold War

Multipolarity -

- the presence of three or more states sharing relatively equal power in the international system
- Example: Pre-WWI, the inter-war period (period of peace)

Each of the distributions of power are expected to be *more or less stable* than the others.

Power implies states' security -

- Stronger states (having greater rel. power) are more secure
- Weaker states (having lesser rel. power) are less secure

Structural Realists/Neorealists -

- **bipolarity to be more stable** than a multipolar system; and unipolarity to be the least stable.
- (Note: Not unanimous.)

Multipolar systems -

- *balanced* or
- *unbalanced* - 3+ states sharing relative power distribution, *and* one potential aggressor (i.e., potential hegemon)

States respond to power dynamics depending on their position in the system (stronger/weaker state).

Examples, include: balancing, buck passing, and bandwagoning

Balancing -

- States **balance** when taking direct action against a rising aggressor
- can be *externally* (e.g., form alliances) or *internally* (e.g., build defensive capabilities)

Offensive/Defensive Realism

Offensive Realism -

- assumes states balance against the greatest *power* in the international system

Defensive Realism -

- assumes states balance against the great *threat* to their interests

Can balancing fail?

Can balancing fail?

Yes.

Underbalancing -

- when states fail to recognize the threat posed by another state, choose not to react to that threat, or to respond imprudently

The **Security Dilemma** -

- occurs when the actions taken by one state to increase its security through military buildup causes military build among other (adversarial) states, leading to *inadvertent wars*

Additional State Responses

Buck passing -

- States **"pass the buck"** when they fail to respond to a rising great power in hopes that *another state* more threatened by the rising power will act
- typically by great power who have geographic barriers/distance from a rising power

Bandwagoning -

- States align themselves with stronger states to counter a rising power
- Requires sacrificing gains and positioning in the international system
- A strategy of *weaker* states

Fundamentally, states' survival depends on their relative power and security compared to other states.

However, other factors may need to be considered.

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We refer to these as *structural modifiers*.

Structural Modifiers

Structural modifiers -

- alter the distribution of power in the international structure by adding to (or taking from) states' relative security.
- *geography* and *technology*

Geography -

- The impact of a state's military power diminishes over distance and other natural obstacles
- Examples - Mountains, desserts, temperatures, bodies of water

Technology -

- advances alter state's capabilities
- can eliminate advantages of distance
- can interfere with the "offensive-defensive balance" by increasing the likelihood of conflict when technology favors expansionist states and decreasing its likelihood when technology favors defense

Signaling and Credibility

The absence of a central authority (i.e., anarchy) means that states constantly seek to "help themselves" against the potential they are threatened by other states.

- In addition to power considerations and structural modifiers, states are left to *assume the intentions of another*.
- Conflict may arise between states as a result of *misinterpretations of states actions*, rather than true intentions to aggress.
- To avoid misinterpretations (later lecture), states may signal their intentions.

Can signaling fail to prevent war?

Can signaling fail to prevent war?

Certainly.

Signaling failures:

- when states lack credibility among other states
- actions are misinterpreted

Signaling requires state **credibility**.

- States need to be *believed*

Credibility -

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- States need to be *believed*
- achieved by "follow through"
- consistency in a state's foreign policy

Credibility -

- Signaling requires state **credibility**
- States need to be *believed*
- achieved by "follow through"
- consistency in a state's foreign policy
- however, states may find themselves in a **credibility trap**

The **credibility trap** -

- occurs when states engage in conflict or remain in a conflict for longer than intended because of a concern for their credibility

Next lecture: Liberalism: Economic Liberalism, Liberal Institutions and the Democratic Peace